‘look into the past and then project into the future a new vision for his country’, said Henry Kissinger.

Through his determined endeavours, Ratan made the Tata Group akin to a ‘nation state’, building institutions, not businesses; this is the primary reason why the group has grown from strength to strength while many other industrial houses became irrelevant over the years, says Sunil Bharti Mittal.

According to Bhaskar Bhat, Ratan is seen as a ‘go-getter displaying [an appetite for] risk’. Ratan too confesses that he has a high risk-taking appetite. He was quoted by a leading national daily saying: ‘I am not a gambler. But I love to take risks. If I believe in something, I would do it vigorously.’ He takes up challenges and creates ‘audacious goals’ that are often seen as ‘unachievable’, says Girish Wagh. And along with that he makes sure he removes the ‘fear of failure’ from his co-workers’ minds, the Tata Motors veteran adds.

N.R. Narayana Murthy, retired chairman of the tech giant Infosys, lists seven attributes that he found remarkable in Ratan. Ratan is ‘courteous and curious’, has a ‘dream for India’, has a ‘high energy level’, is ‘daring’, has ‘deep knowledge, decency and humility’, is concerned about the ‘good of the country’, and has evident ‘optimism’ and is a ‘role model for every Indian’, he says.

Kissinger adds, ‘One of his great attributes is his ability to formulate his objectives in a way that his opposite number can share so that it does not become just a Tata issue but a joint issue.’ When Azim Premji was asked about Ratan’s ‘blind spots’, he strongly averred, ‘In our relationship of over three decades, I have not noticed any blind spots.’

Ratan’s popularity is like that of a rockstar. From heads of state to the man on the street, the name Ratan Tata evokes immediate admiration. Within the country, perhaps, no business leader has been as popular and adulated as him.

In any gathering of the country’s or world’s who’s who, it is not unusual to see the largest congregation around Ratan. I have observed how, when he would arrive at Rashtrapati Bhavan to attend banquets for visiting heads of states, most guests would rush to be with Ratan leaving other dignitaries looking a tad envious.

Praveer Sinha remembers the time when Ratan was at the Parliament House on 30 June 2017 for the launch of the goods and services tax (GST). ‘It had to be seen to be believed,’ he recalls. Many jostled to take selfies